

## US Life Science Tools & Diagnostics

# US Life Science Tools & Diagnostics: Monthly sector health tracker (August data)



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*We publish a monthly life science tools & diagnostics sector health tracker to aggregate 1) qualitative commentary from major events, and 2) quantitative data that can help us assess market trends and sentiments. Our last published issue is available [here](#).*

**From a qualitative perspective, commentary at September conferences is trending positive (with the sector up meaningfully in the last few days).** We will provide a full synthesis in our next monthly tracker, after all the September conferences have finished.

**From a quantitative perspective, August sector health metrics are mixed: drug approvals and pharma & biotech generally continued to stay strong, while academic & government (both federal and international) was roughly flat to down.** The cleanest positives: New drug approvals increased again, while clinical trial starts stabilized sequentially after July's decline (and was up comfortably YoY). Biotech funding also remained broadly steady at an elevated level and is now up 67% on a TTM basis. The most misleading negative: Licensing deal value declined again sequentially, but remains up 40% on a TTM basis, suggesting that the monthly weakness is more likely volatility than a deterioration in the underlying funding environment. Mixed, but we tend to interpret as negative: Academic & Government metrics. Within the US, NIH funding and awards increased sequentially off a tough comp, but are still down YoY and the TTM growth - while positive - slowed down. NIH outlays, US contract awards for life science tools & diagnostics, and UK healthcare grants (excl. Our Future Health) all improved sequentially off an easy comp, but are still down YoY and over the TTM.

For a deeper dive on the new quantitative Academic & Government datapoints included in this monthly tracker for the first time, see our recent note: [US Life Science Tools & Diagnostics: Is Academic & Government spend actually improving? \(what datapoints beyond the NIH tell us\)](#)

*Please see the [Appendix](#) for disclosures of companies in this note that are not covered, or that are covered by other Bernstein analysts.*

## BERNSTEIN TICKER TABLE

| Ticker              | Rating | Cur | 17 Sep<br>2026   | Price<br>Target | TTM           | Adjusted EPS |        |        |       | Adjusted P/E (x) |         |       |
|---------------------|--------|-----|------------------|-----------------|---------------|--------------|--------|--------|-------|------------------|---------|-------|
|                     |        |     | Closing<br>Price |                 | Rel.<br>Perf. | Cur          | 2025A  | 2026E  | 2027E | 2025A            | 2026E   | 2027E |
| A (Agilent )        | O      | USD | 156.34           | 180.00          | 7.7%          | USD          | 5.59   | 6.21   | 6.92  | 28.0             | 25.2    | 22.6  |
| AVTR (Avantor )     | M      | USD | 15.86            | 15.50           | 12.2%         | USD          | 0.90   | 0.82   | 0.88  | 17.6             | 19.3    | 18.0  |
| GH (Guardant)       | O      | USD | 183.10           | 210.00          | 204.4%        | USD          | (1.82) | (1.18) | 1.70  | 25.7             | 18.5    | 12.4  |
| ILMN (Illumina)     | M      | USD | 245.18           | 215.00          | 127.3%        | USD          | 4.86   | 5.34   | 6.14  | 50.5             | 45.9    | 39.9  |
| RVTY (Revvity)      | M      | USD | 146.73           | 120.00          | 56.1%         | USD          | 5.06   | 5.32   | 5.90  | 29.0             | 27.6    | 24.9  |
| TMO (Thermo Fisher) | M      | USD | 658.32           | 575.00          | 23.6%         | USD          | 22.87  | 25.12  | 27.59 | 28.8             | 26.2    | 23.9  |
| NTRA (Natera)       | O      | USD | 366.31           | 365.00          | 93.1%         | USD          | (1.53) | (1.36) | 0.57  | (239.4)          | (268.9) | 642.4 |
| WAT (Waters)        | O      | USD | 429.72           | 450.00          | 25.8%         | USD          | 13.13  | 14.64  | 17.00 | 32.7             | 29.4    | 25.3  |
| SPX                 |        |     | 7,637.76         |                 |               |              |        |        |       |                  |         |       |

O - Outperform, M - Market-Perform, U - Underperform, NR - Not Rated, CS - Coverage Suspended

NTRA estimate is Reported EPS; GH valuation is EV/Sales (x); NTRA valuation is Reported P/E (x);

Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein estimates and analysis.

## INVESTMENT IMPLICATIONS

We rate Waters, Agilent, Guardant, and Natera Outperform. We rate Thermo Fisher, Avantor, Revvity, and Illumina Market-Perform.

## DETAILS

## SYNTHESIS OF FINDINGS

### QUANTITATIVE DATA

We track several quantitative metrics of sector health, on both an annual and monthly basis. This table synthesizes changes year-over-year and month-over-month (full detail included later in the note). We report these metrics on a monthly basis, except for pharma R&D Spend, which is updated quarterly.

**EXHIBIT 1: AT A GLANCE: August sector health metrics are mixed: drug approvals and pharma & biotech generally continued to stay strong, while academic & government (both federal and international) was roughly flat to down**

| Metric (2026 August) |                                                      | Compared to prior year                |                       | Compared to prior month*   |                   | Source                          |
|----------------------|------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|-----------------------|----------------------------|-------------------|---------------------------------|
|                      |                                                      | Trailing 12 months vs 12 months prior | YoY change            | Previous sequential growth | Sequential growth |                                 |
| Drug approvals       | New drugs (CDER)                                     | 55 vs 48                              | 7 vs 5                | 6 vs 3                     | 7 vs 6            | FDA                             |
|                      | Biosimilars                                          | Pending update                        |                       | 2 vs 1                     | Pending update    | FDA                             |
| Pharma & biotech     | Clinical trial starts                                | 9%                                    | 8%                    | -10%                       | 0%                | ClinicalTrials.gov              |
|                      | Licensing deals                                      | 40%                                   | -39%                  | -58%                       | -32%              | Bloomberg                       |
|                      | Biotech funding                                      | 67%                                   | 79%                   | 1%                         | -1%               | Bloomberg                       |
|                      | Pharma R&D spend**                                   | 7%                                    | 8% (2026Q2 vs 2025Q2) | 5% (26Q2 vs 26Q1)          |                   | Bloomberg                       |
| US federal spend     | NIH federal budget (Annual)                          | +1% (2026 vs 2025)                    | N/A                   | N/A                        | N/A               | Congressional Research Services |
|                      | NIH funding and awards (Monthly)                     | 6%                                    | -14%                  | 10%                        | 23%               | USASpending.gov                 |
|                      | NIH Outlays (Monthly)                                | -2%                                   | -10%                  | -15%                       | 8%                | Fiscaldata.treasury.gov         |
|                      | Contract awards for life science tools & diagnostics | -13%                                  | -46%                  | -32%                       | 33%               | USASpending.gov                 |
| International spend  | Horizon Europe healthcare grants                     | Pending update                        |                       | -61%                       | Pending update    | the European Data Portal        |
|                      | China S&T spending (July data)***                    | 4%                                    | 3%                    | 69%                        | -56%              | China Ministry of Finance       |
|                      | U.K. healthcare grants                               | 7%                                    | -79%                  | -95%                       | 467%              | UK Research and Innovation      |
|                      | U.K. healthcare grants (excl. Our Future Health)     | -40%                                  |                       |                            |                   | UK Research and Innovation      |

\*The monthly growth rate compares the normalized value per day to such measure in the prior month. \*\*Pharma R&D spend is shown using quarterly data, not monthly data. \*\*\*China S&T spending is reported with a one-month lag due to the Ministry of Finance's publication schedule.

Cells marked as "pending update" do not yet have data available for this period.

Source: Bernstein analysis, additional sources as noted in the table

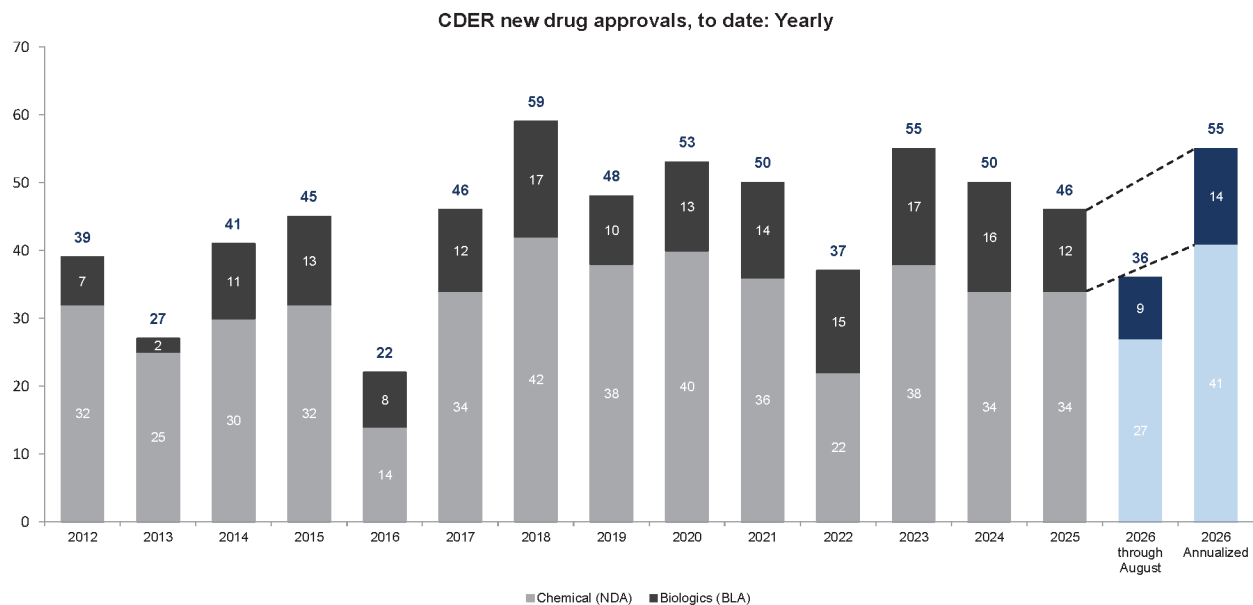


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## DETAILED QUANTITATIVE DATA

### DRUG APPROVALS: NEW DRUGS

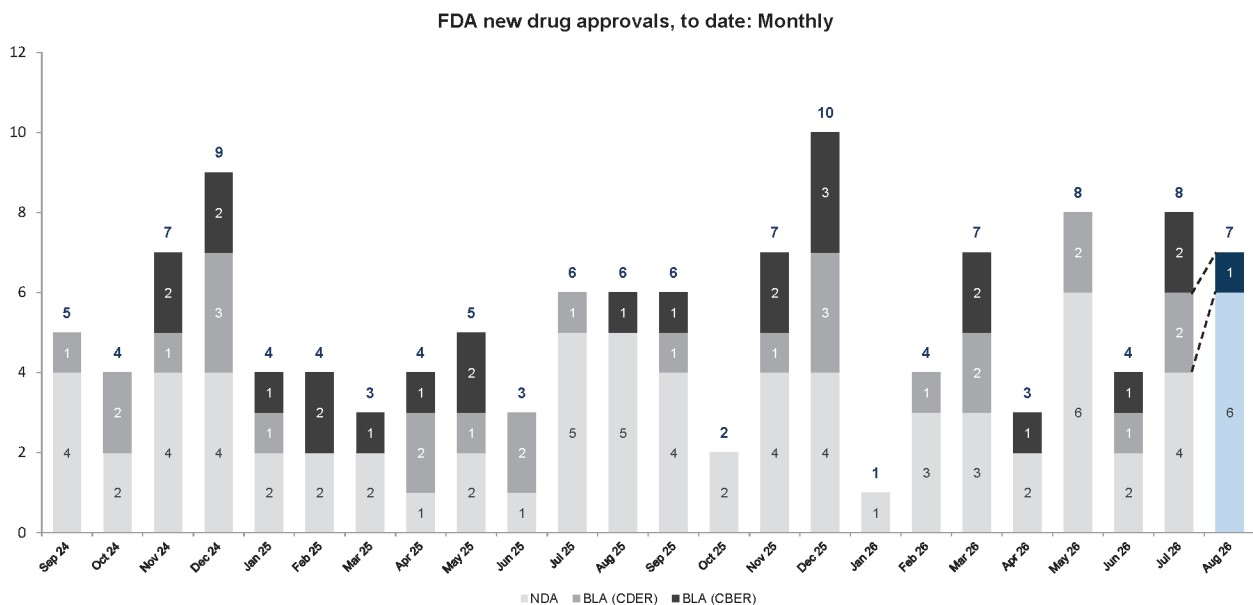
EXHIBIT 2: On an annualized basis, 2026 new drug approvals are trending above 2025 levels



Reflects data from CDER only. Will not reconcile with monthly graph below, which includes data from both CDER and CBER

Source: FDA, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 3: There were seven novel drug approvals by the FDA in August: 6 chemical drugs and 1 biologic drug

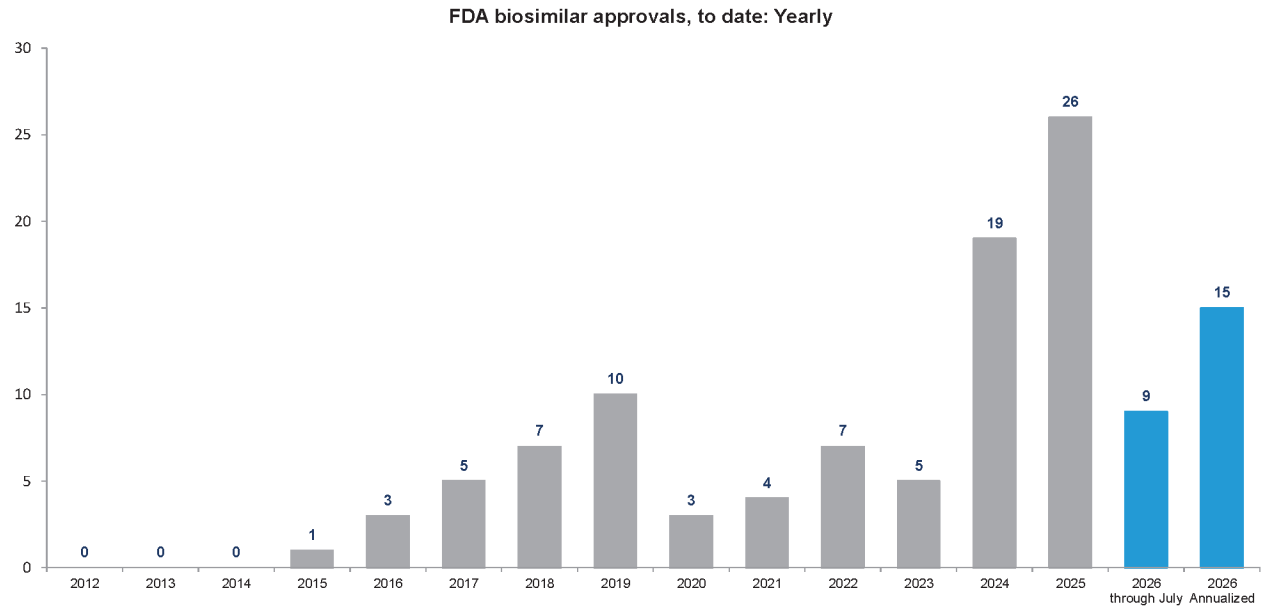


CBER data is available from the FDA with last update 8/20/2026.

Source: FDA, Bernstein analysis

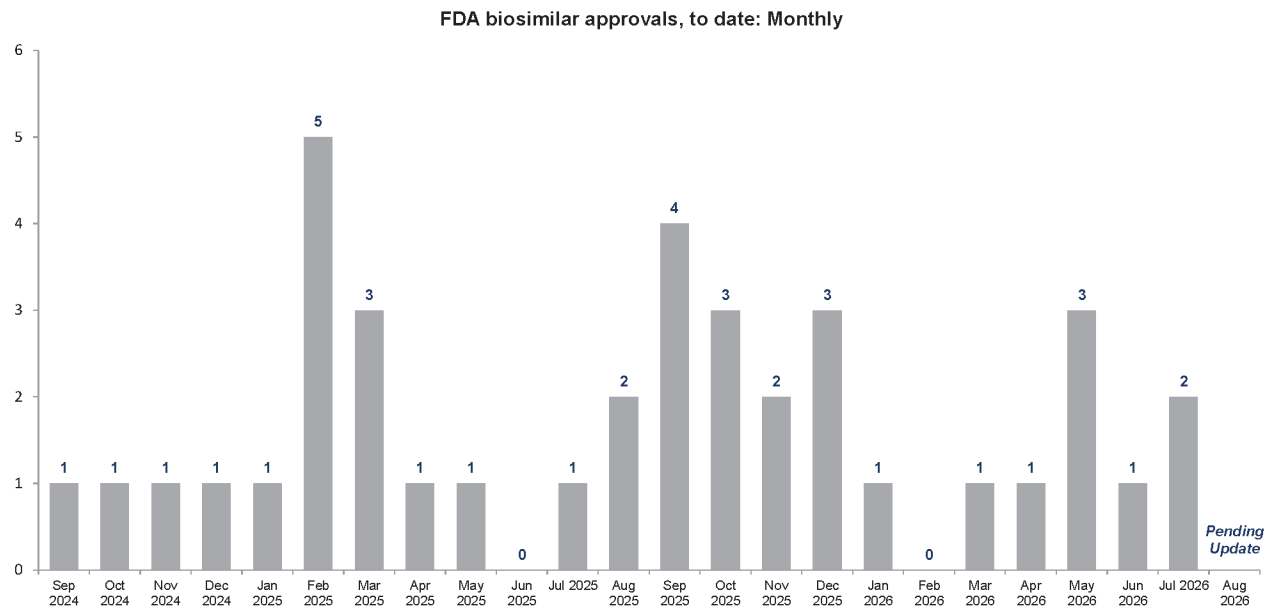
DRUG APPROVALS: BIOSIMILARS

EXHIBIT 4: On an annualized basis, 2026 is trending below 2025 (a very tough comp) for biosimilar drug approvals



Biosimilar data is available from the FDA with last update 8/4/2026.  
Source: FDA, Bernstein analysis

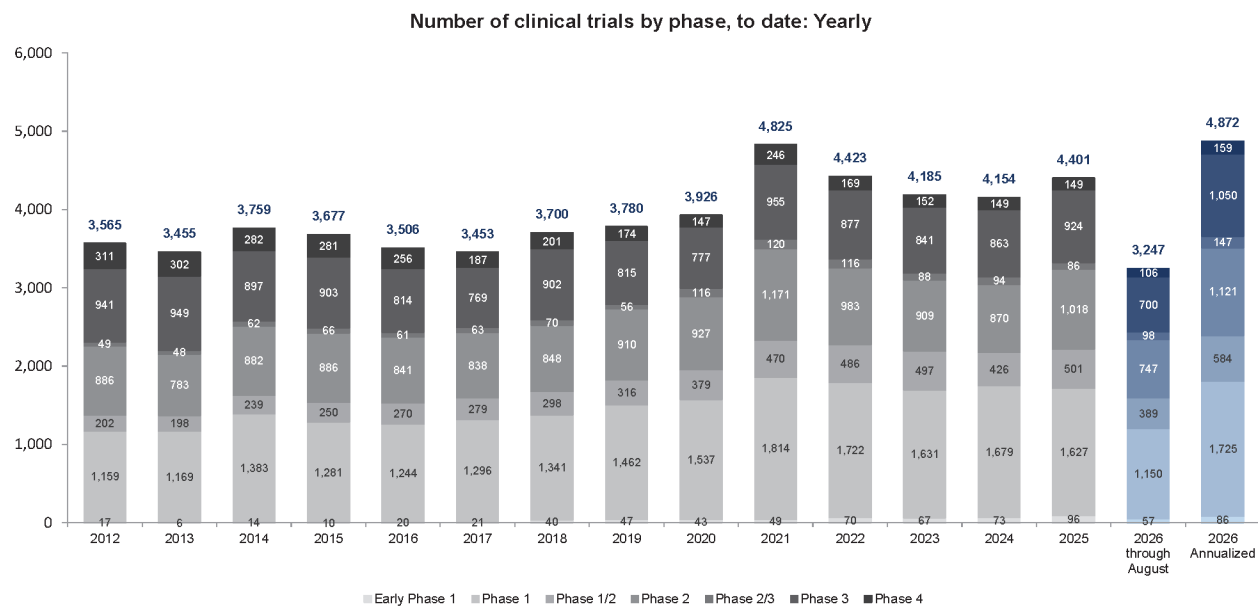
EXHIBIT 5: There were two biosimilars approved in July 2026; August approval data have not yet been published by the FDA



Biosimilar data is available from the FDA with last update 8/4/2026.  
Source: FDA, Bernstein analysis

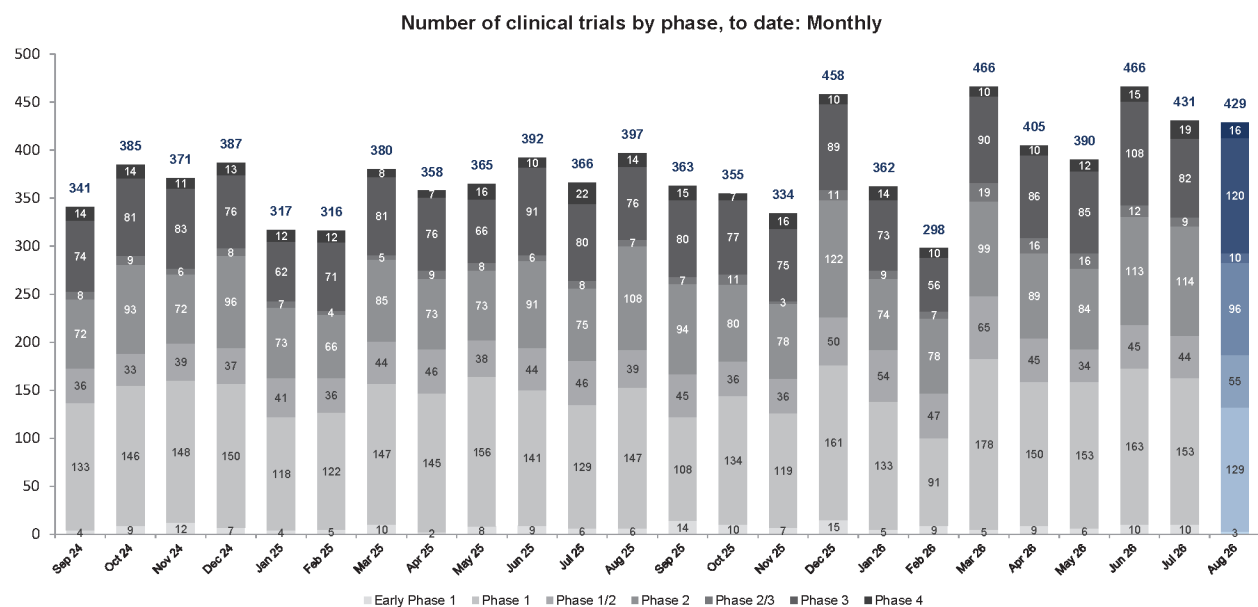
## CLINICAL TRIAL STARTS

**EXHIBIT 6: On an annualized basis, 2026 clinical trial starts are trending above any prior year in the last ~decade and a half (though month-to-month variability can make this metric tricky to annualize)**



Updated as of 9/9/2026. Results of industry sponsored, interventional, early phase 1 - phase 4 trials. Clinical trial starts number can vary at each pull from trial sponsors updating trial start dates retrospectively.  
Source: ClinicalTrials.gov, Bernstein analysis

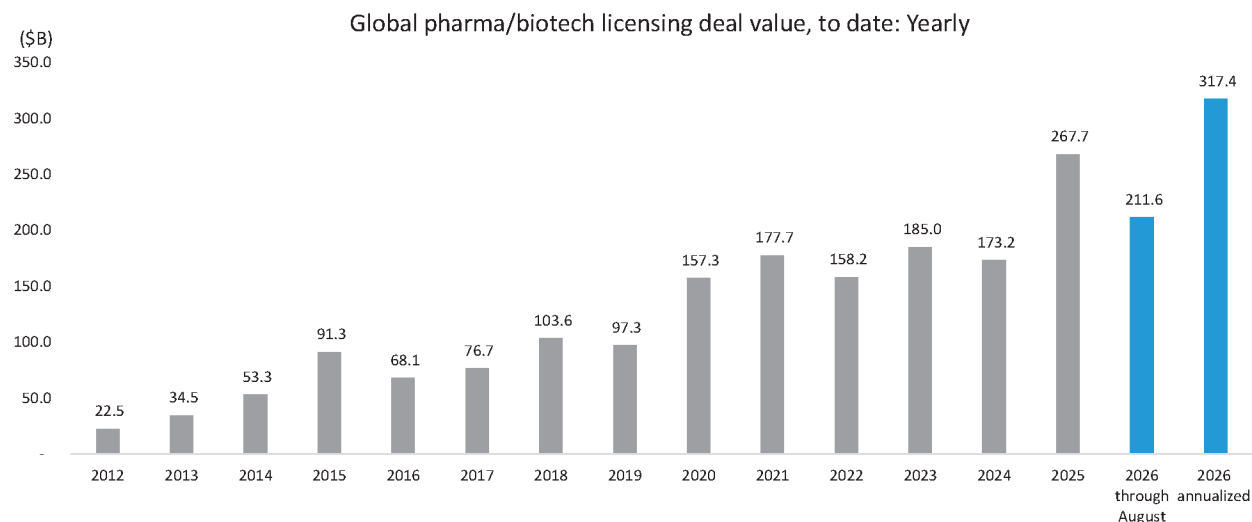
## EXHIBIT 7: Clinical trial starts in August 2026 trended ~flat sequentially, and were up 8% YoY



Updated as of 9/9/2026. Results of industry sponsored, interventional, early phase 1 - phase 4 trials. Clinical trial starts number can vary at each pull from trial sponsors updating trial start dates retrospectively.  
Source: ClinicalTrials.gov, Bernstein analysis

## LICENSING DEALS

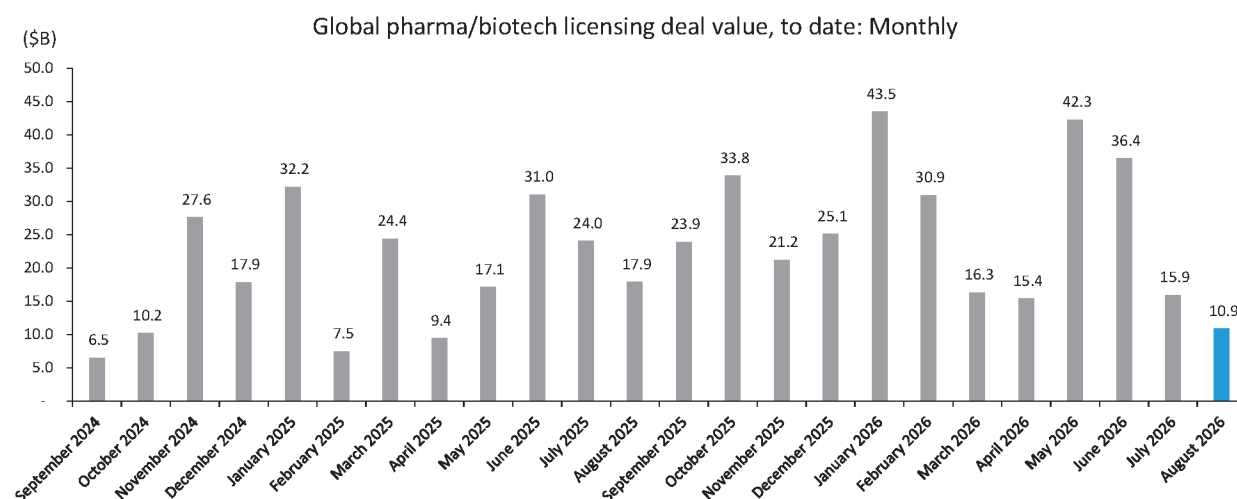
### EXHIBIT 8: On an annualized basis, 2026 is trending well above 2025 for global pharma/biotech licensing deals



Updated as of 9/10/2026. Data may vary slightly at each pull from database retrospective updates.

Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein analysis

### EXHIBIT 9: Global pharma/biotech licensing deal value declined sequentially and YoY in August 2026

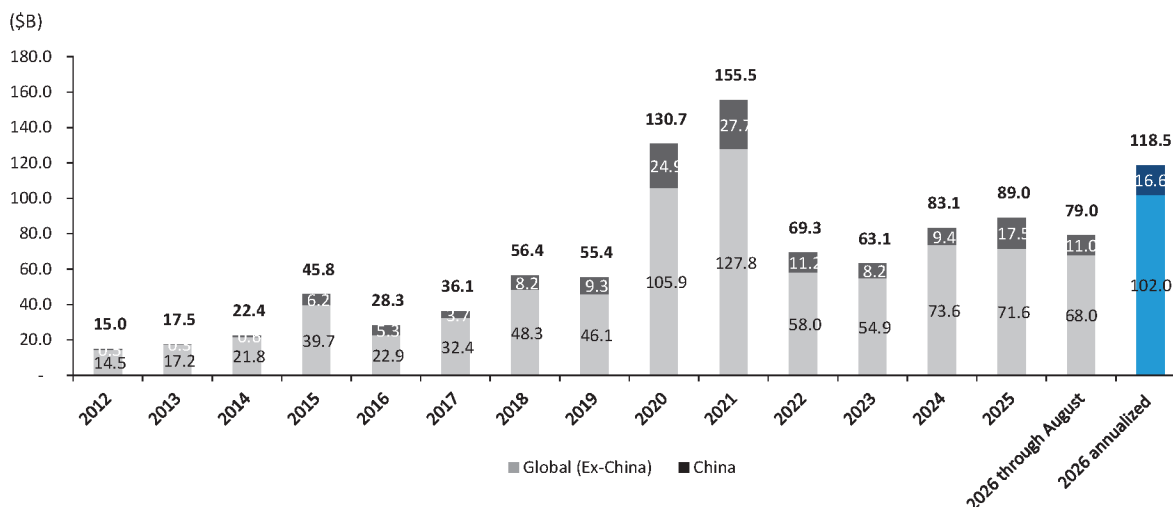


Updated as of 9/10/2026. Data may vary slightly at each pull from database retrospective updates.

Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein analysis

**BIOTECH FUNDING**EXHIBIT 10: **On an annualized basis, 2026 is trending comfortably above 2025 levels for biotech funding**

Global biotech funding (IPO, PE, VC, and FO): Yearly

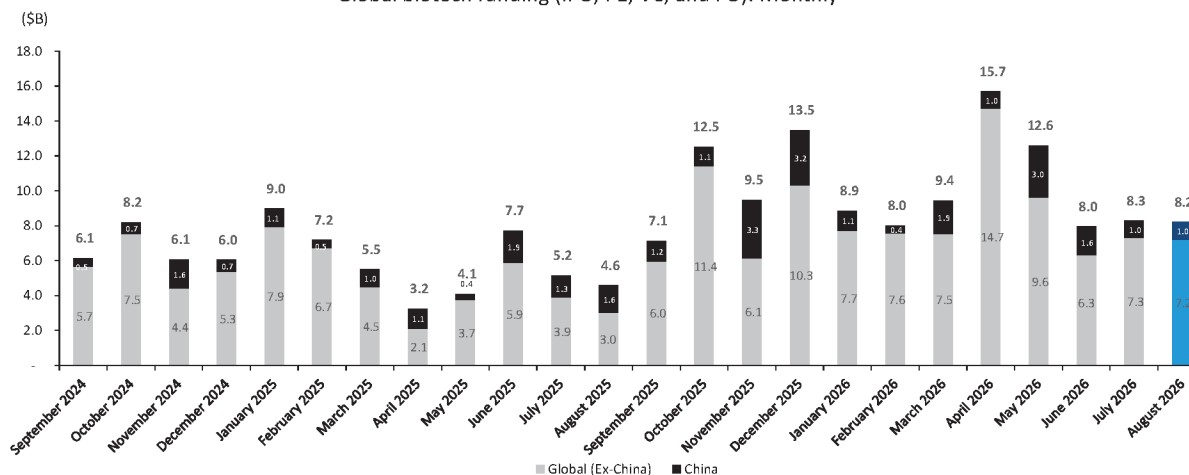


Updated as of 9/10/2026. Data may vary slightly at each pull from database retrospective updates.

Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 11: **Global biotech funding in August 2026 trended ~flat sequentially, and were up 79% YoY**

Global biotech funding (IPO, PE, VC, and FO): Monthly

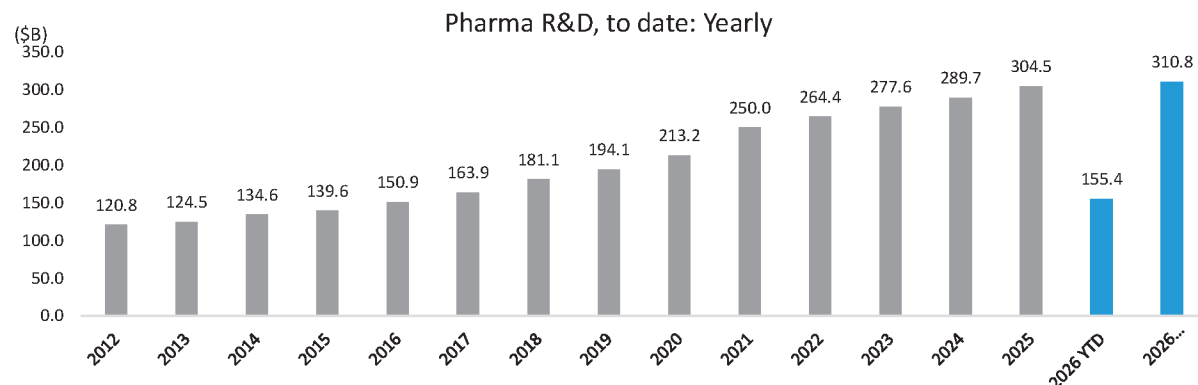


Updated as of 9/10/2026. Data may vary slightly at each pull from database retrospective updates.

Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein analysis

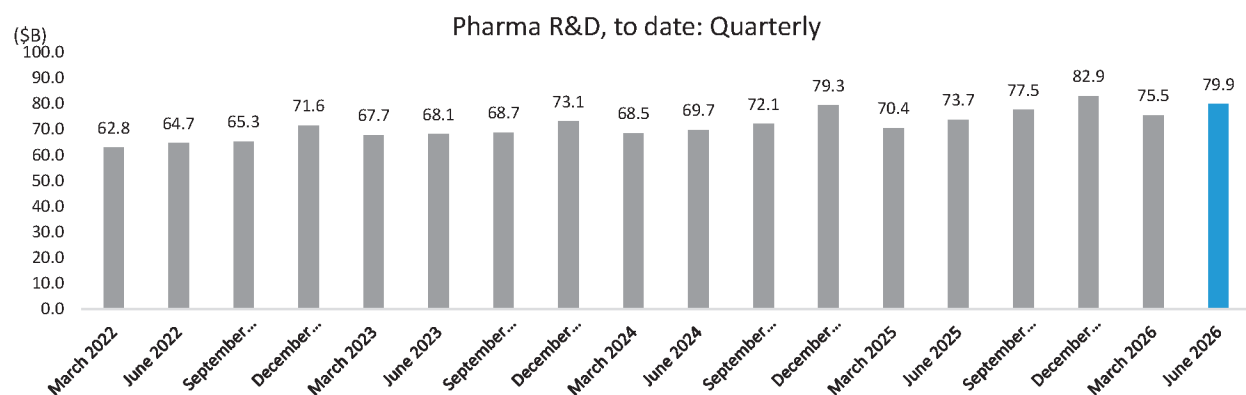
## PHARMA R&D SPEND

EXHIBIT 12: **On an annualized basis, pharma R&D spend in 2026 is trending above 2025 levels.**



Updated as of 8/13/2026, reflect data through 26Q2.  
Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 13: **Pharma R&D spend grew 8% in 26Q2 versus 25Q2; 26Q2 grew ~5% sequentially vs 26Q1**



Reflects quarter spend for the quarter ending the month displayed. Updated as of August 2026.  
Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein analysis

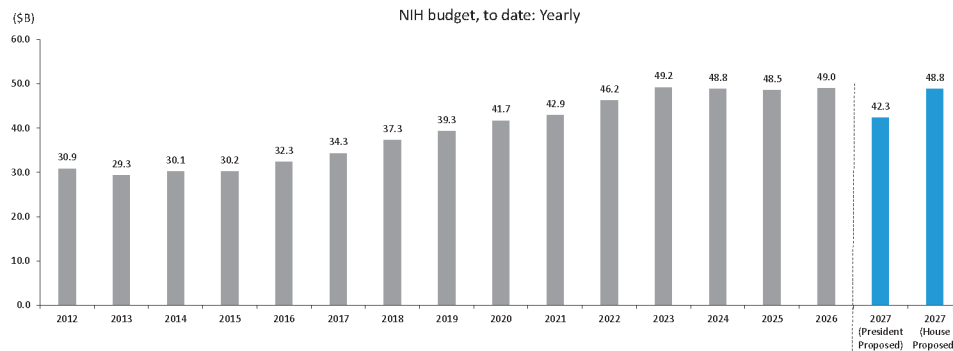
EXHIBIT 14: **2Q26 drivers of notable pharma R&D step-up**

| Company        | % Total Industry R&D | Company R&D YoY Growth % | Company R&D YoY \$ SM (after adjustment of one-timers) | Company Commentary                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 | Clinical / Late stage pipeline | Early stage/ Preclinical pipeline | Manufacturing | Personnel | External / Other | One-time component excluded                                                                       |
|----------------|----------------------|--------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------|-----------------------------------|---------------|-----------|------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| MRK US Equity  | 5.3%                 | 11.8%                    | 447.0                                                  | The increase was largely due to a \$5.7 billion charge for the acquisition of Terna and higher clinical development spending, partially offset by a \$200 million reduction in R&D expenses as part of a funding agreement with Blackstone Life Sciences (Blackstone).                                                                                                                                                                                             | ↑                              |                                   |               |           | ↑                | Terna acquisition charge and Blackstone funding offset excluded from recurring driver assessment. |
| LLY US Equity  | 4.8%                 | 14.5%                    | 482.9                                                  | Driven by continued investments in the company's early and late-stage portfolio, including more than 40 active Phase 3 programs.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   | ↑                              | ↑                                 |               |           |                  |                                                                                                   |
| BIIB US Equity | 0.6%                 | 24.1%                    | 94.8                                                   | The increase in second quarter 2026 GAAP R&D expense included approximately \$38 million of step-up amortization related to SKYCLARYS inventory used in clinical trials. The increase in second quarter 2026 GAAP and Non-GAAP R&D expense was driven by higher spend on clinical trials, including felzartamab, salarsen and titifimab, as well as the inclusion of operating expenses from Apellis, and a reduction in R&D funding received from Royalty Pharma. | ↑                              |                                   |               |           | ↑                | SKYCLARYS inventory step-up amortization excluded.                                                |
| ARGX BB Equity | 0.6%                 | 48.3%                    | 158.3                                                  | The research and development expenses mainly relate to advancing edgartimod, empasiprubart, and adimanebart across multiple registrational studies, plus early-stage pipeline and preclinical programs.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            | ↑                              | ↑                                 |               |           |                  |                                                                                                   |
| RVMD US Equity | 0.5%                 | 76.2%                    | 170.8                                                  | The increase was primarily driven by higher clinical trial and manufacturing expenses for daras-onasib and zoldonasib, increased personnel-related costs due to additional headcount, and higher stock-based compensation expense related to changes in retirement provisions for equity awards and increased headcount.                                                                                                                                           | ↑                              |                                   | ↑             | ↑         |                  |                                                                                                   |
| VKTX US Equity | 0.1%                 | 92.4%                    | 55.6                                                   | The increase was primarily due to increased expenses related to clinical studies, salaries and benefits, stock-based compensation and third-party consultants, partially offset by decreased expenses related to manufacturing for our drug candidates and preclinical studies.                                                                                                                                                                                    | ↑                              | ↓                                 | ↓             | ↑         | ↑                |                                                                                                   |

Source: Company reports, Bloomberg, Bernstein analysis

## NIH

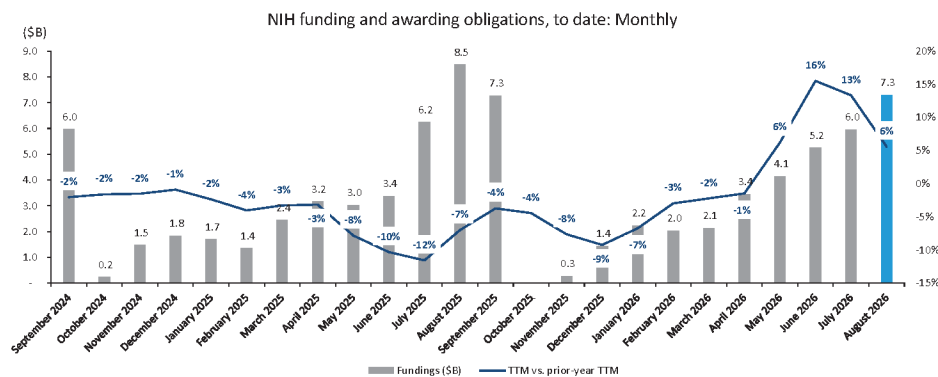
**EXHIBIT 15: The White House attempted to cut the NIH budget in 2026 but the enacted budget slightly increased YoY. The 2027 budget is still in process; the president proposed a 14% cut, and the House appropriations committee countered with a ~flat budget.**



FY22-FY27 (proposed) includes ARPA-H funding. The appropriate comparison for the FY2027 proposals is the FY2026 appropriation level of ~\$48.7 billion, including ARPA-H. Historical figures reflect enacted program levels, including applicable transfers and other funding sources, and are not directly comparable with the proposed FY2027 level.

Source: Congressional Research Service, NIH, whitehouse.gov, Senate, House, Bernstein analysis

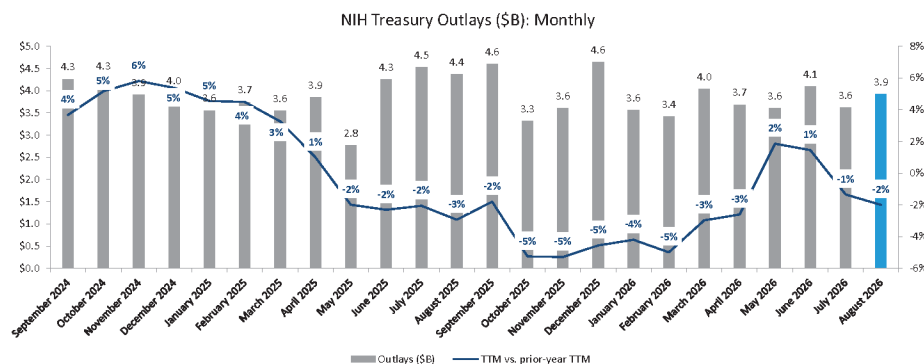
**EXHIBIT 16: August 2026 NIH funding and awarding obligations improved 23% sequentially but were down 14% YoY**



Updated as of 9/9/2026. Shows results for NIH as the awarding and funding agency. Data may vary at each pull due to database retrospective updates.

Source: USAspending.gov, Bernstein analysis

**EXHIBIT 17: NIH outlays improved 8% sequentially but were down 10% YoY**

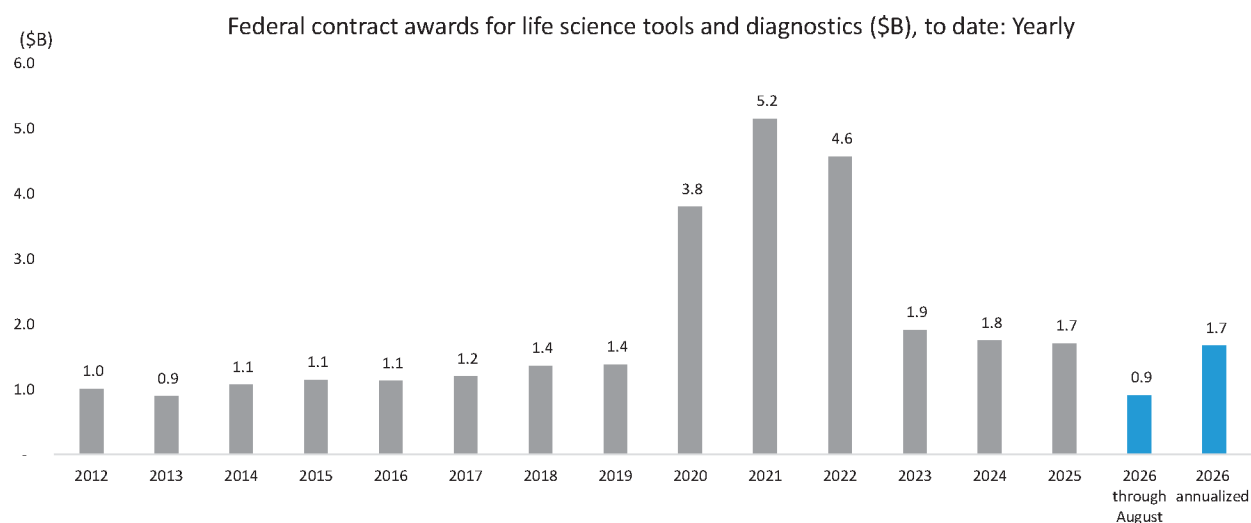


Updated as of 9/11/2026

Source: Treasury.gov Monthly Treasury Statement, Bernstein analysis

## FEDERAL CONTRACT AWARDS FOR LIFE SCIENCE TOOLS AND DIAGNOSTICS

EXHIBIT 18: **On an annualized basis, 2026 federal contract awards for life science tools and diagnostics are trending flat against 2025 levels**

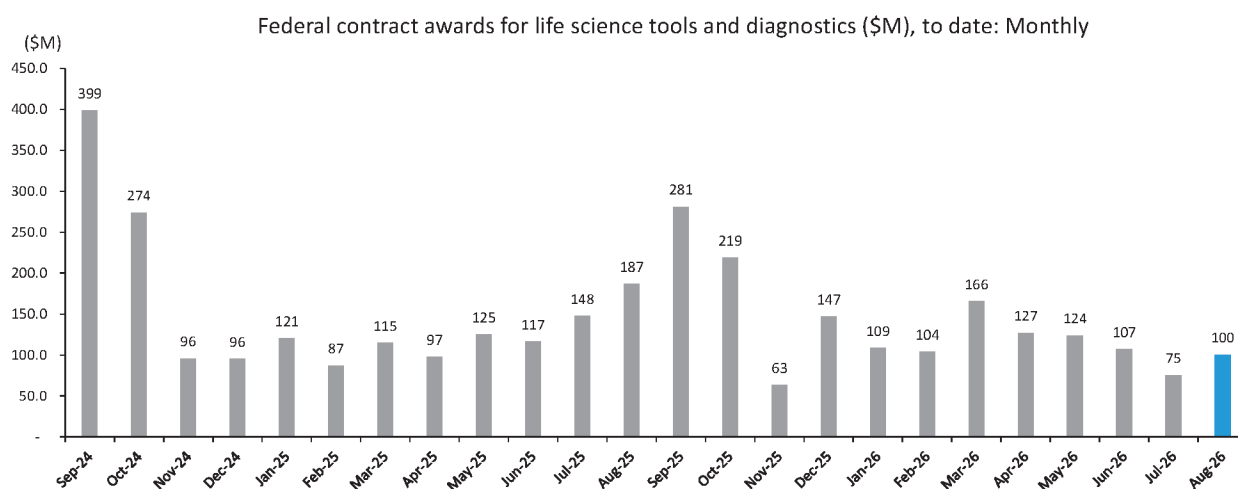


Annualization based on the average YTD share of full-year spending over the past two years. The greater the (unpredictable) monthly volatility, the less reliable the annualized number will be.

Updated as of 9/10/2026. Shows results for Product and Service Code of 6630 (Chemical Analysis Instruments), 6632 (Analysis Instruments, Medical Laboratory Use), 6640 (Laboratory Equipment and Supplies) and 6550 (In Vitro Diagnostic Substances, Reagents, Test Kits and Sets). Data may vary at each pull due to database retrospective updates.

Source: USAspending.gov, Bernstein analysis

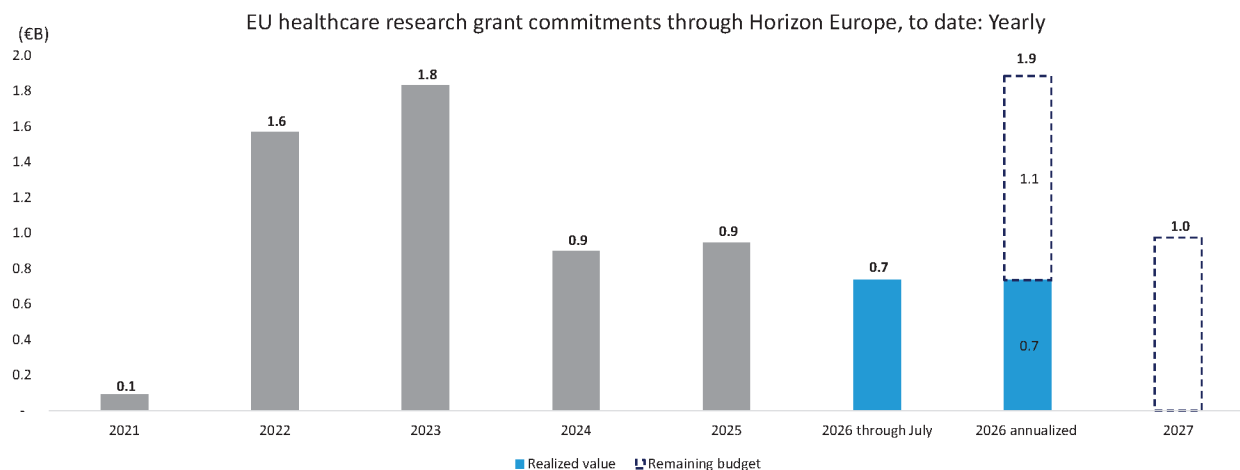
EXHIBIT 19: **August 2026 federal contract awards improved 33% sequentially but were down 46% YoY**



Updated as of 9/10/2026. Shows results for Product and Service Code of 6630 (Chemical Analysis Instruments), 6632 (Analysis Instruments, Medical Laboratory Use), 6640 (Laboratory Equipment and Supplies) and 6550 (In Vitro Diagnostic Substances, Reagents, Test Kits and Sets). Data may vary at each pull due to database retrospective updates.

## HORIZON EUROPE HEALTHCARE GRANTS

EXHIBIT 20: **On an annualized basis, 2026 Horizon Europe healthcare grants are trending well above 2025 levels**



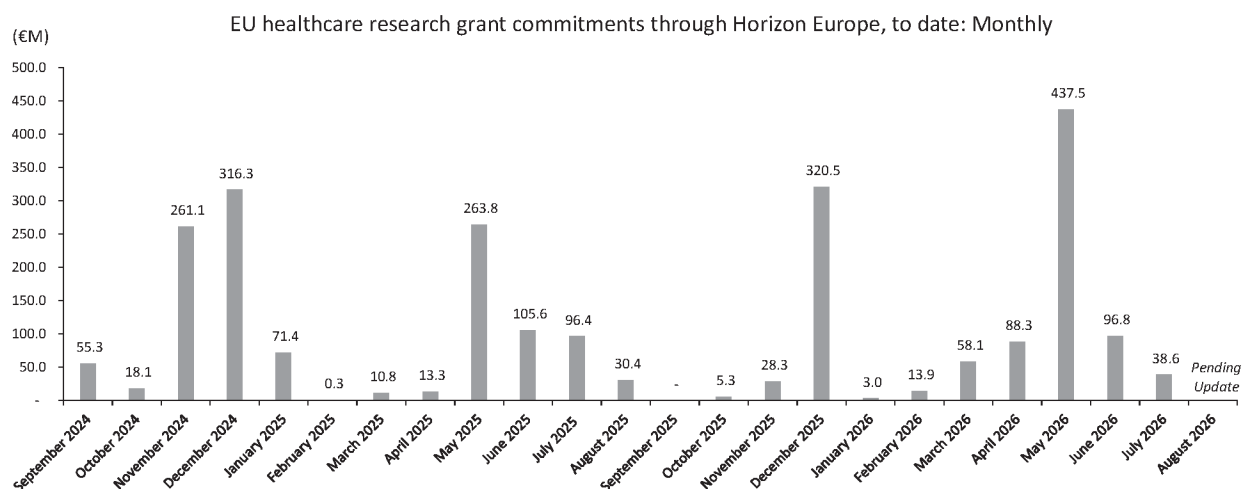
Horizon Europe data is available from the EU with last update 8/6/2026.

Annualization based on the average YTD share of full-year commitments over the past two years. The greater the (unpredictable) monthly volatility, the less reliable the annualized number will be.

Shows results for Horizon Europe Pillar II (Global challenges & European industrial competitiveness) Cluster 1 (Health).

Source: Horizon Europe, the European Data Portal, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 21: **July 2026 Horizon Europe healthcare grants decreased 61% sequentially and 60% YoY; August grant data have not yet been published by the EU**



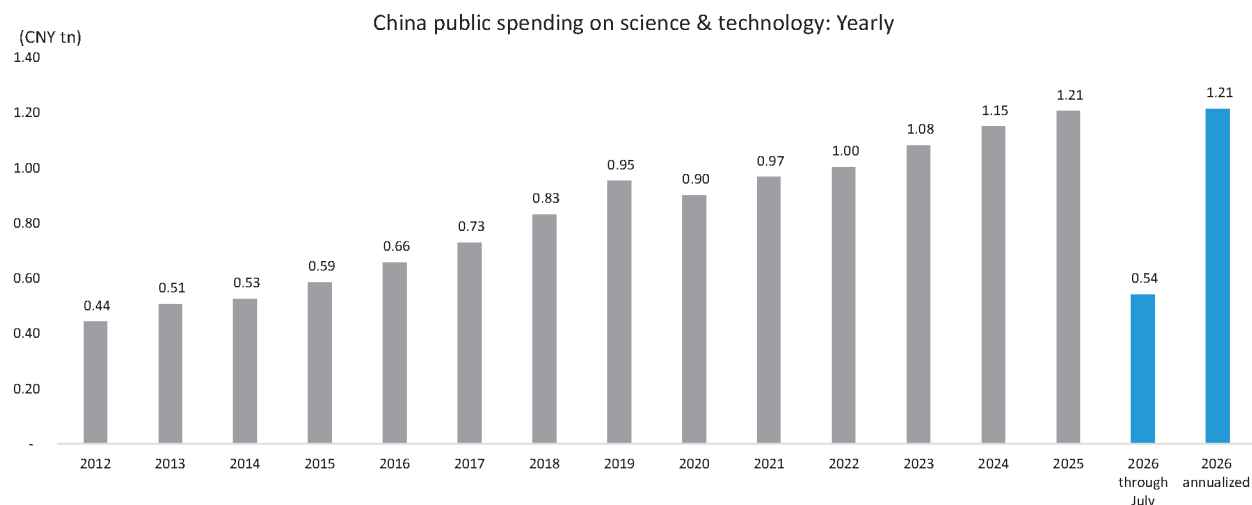
Horizon Europe data is available from the EU with last update 8/6/2026.

Shows results for Horizon Europe Pillar II (Global challenges & European industrial competitiveness) Cluster 1 (Health).

Source: Horizon Europe, the European Data Portal, Bernstein analysis

## CHINA SCIENCE AND TECHNOLOGY SPENDING

EXHIBIT 22: **On an annualized basis, 2026 China public spending on science and technology is trending flat vs 2025**

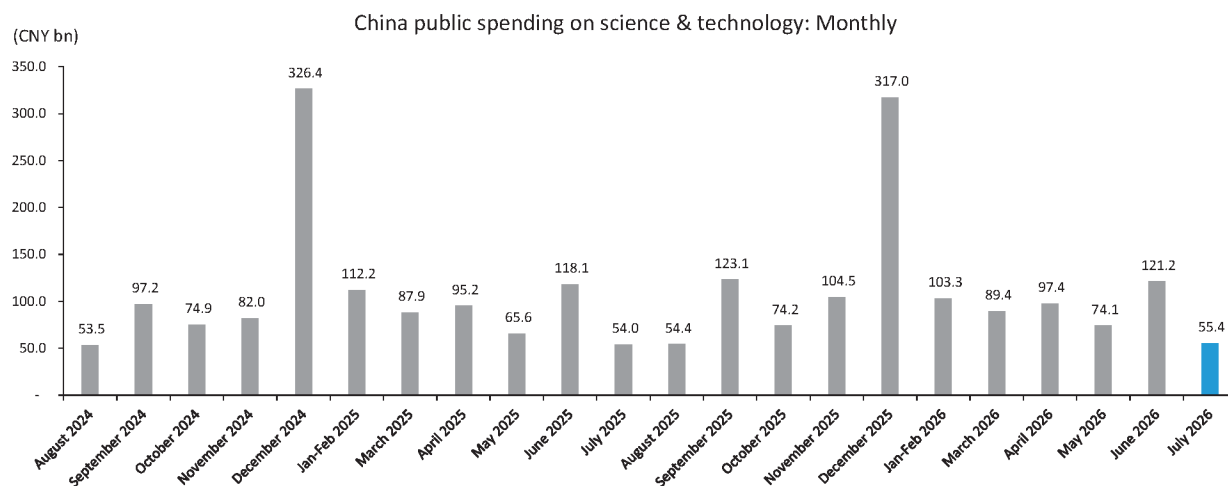


China public spending data is available from the Ministry of Finance with last update 8/21/2026.

Annualization based on the average YTD share of full-year spending over the past two years. The greater the (unpredictable) monthly volatility, the less reliable the annualized number will be.

Source: China Ministry of Finance, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 23: **July 2026 China S&T spending declined 56% sequentially, but were still up 3% YoY**



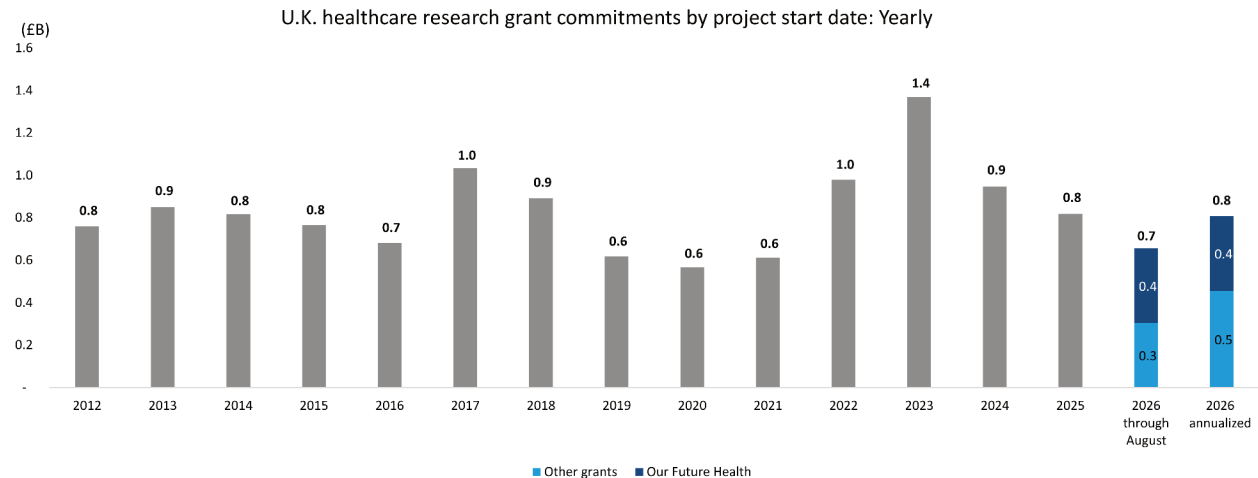
China public spending data is available from the Ministry of Finance with last update 8/21/2026.

January and February presented on a combined basis, as separate monthly figures were not published.

Source: China Ministry of Finance, Bernstein analysis

U.K. HEALTHCARE GRANTS

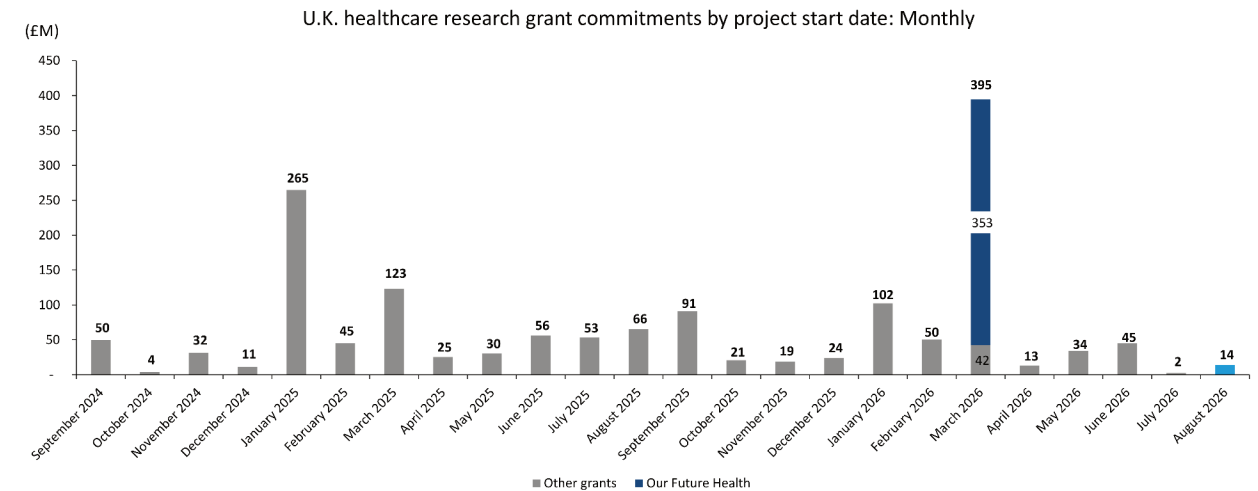
EXHIBIT 24: On an annualized basis, 2026 UKRI healthcare grants are trending flat against 2025 levels



Updated as of 9/10/2026. Shows results for funding from Biotechnology and Biological Sciences Research Council (BBSRC) or Medical Research Council (MRC). Data may vary at each pull due to database retrospective updates. Annualization of "other grants" excludes Our Future Health, which is the UK's largest-ever health research program. It launched in 2022 and was designed to build a longitudinal dataset from up to five million volunteers to support the development and validation of improved disease prevention, early detection, and treatment.

Source: UK Research and Innovation (UKRI), Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 25: August 2026 UKRI healthcare grants improved 467% sequentially but were down 79% YoY



Updated as of 9/10/2026. Shows results for funding from Biotechnology and Biological Sciences Research Council (BBSRC) or Medical Research Council (MRC). Data may vary at each pull due to database retrospective updates. Our Future Health is the UK's largest-ever health research program, launched initially in 2022 and designed to build a longitudinal dataset from up to five million volunteers to support the development and validation of improved approaches to disease prevention, early detection and treatment.

Source: UK Research and Innovation (UKRI), Bernstein analysis



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## APPENDIX: COMPANY DISCLOSURES

*In this note we refer to companies that are not covered by Bernstein, or are covered by other Bernstein analysts, or are private companies. Here we provide detail on those companies that we do not cover.*

**Not covered:** Viking Therapeutics (VCTX)

**Covered by other Bernstein analysts:** Merck (MRK, Courtney Breen), Eli Lilly (LLY, Courtney Breen), Biogen (BIIB, Jeffrey Walch), Argenx (ARGX, Justin Smith), Revolution Medicine (RVMD, Jeffrey Walch)

## DISCLOSURE APPENDIX

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